fear or favour. Illiterate masses are often misled by party workers and guided by sentiments, favours and rhetoric. A sound public opinion can be formed only in the environment of free thought and knowledge.

(a) Poverty: The poor in any country are easily influenced by the false promise of political leaders and cast their votes subjectively. Sound and objective public opinion is possible only by alleviating poverty.

(b) Racist and Caste based Discrimination: Sentiments that provoke discrimination based on caste, creed and religion create a divide among the masses that are often manipulated by political parties for their advantage. Social disharmony in the country is detrimental to the effective working of a democracy.

(c) Freedom of speech and the media:



Unbiased, objective and independent media as well as respect for individual freedom of speech and assembly play a very significant role in the formation of healthy opinion. The vital importance of an independent and impartial media that respects peoples freedom and exercises responsible news reporting are important criteria for formation of mature and responsive public opinion.

10.3 Definition of Political Parties

Political parties are indispensable instruments in a democratic system. They are formed with definite ideologies, and programme of action. They enlighten the general public on issues concerning the society and state and they also prescribe alternatives. Through propaganda they educate people on political issues and garner their support for their policies and programme.

There is consistent competition between the various political parties and this competition ensures the mature functioning of a democracy.

ACTIVITY

Following are the lists of various functions of political parties in a democracy:

- Parties contest in elections
- Parties put forward different policies and programmes
- Parties make laws for the country
- Parties form and run government
- Parities play the role of the opposition
- Parties shape public opinion
- Parties provide people the access to government welfare schemes

Follow the newspaper for one month and collect news items related to the various functions of political parties

Quotable quote

In a democracy public opinion is harnessed through political parties.

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